COVER & CONTINUITY

Planning your practice cover

A step-by-step checklist for planned time away: who covers whom, what is shared, and how clients are told.

AUDIENCE	FORMAT	VERSION	TIME
Psychologists · Psychiatrists	Checklist	1.0 · Nov 2026	20 minutes

WHAT IT IS	A practical checklist for arranging temporary cover for your clients while you are on leave, at a conference or otherwise away.
USE IT WHEN	Two to six weeks before planned time away, or when you set up a cover plan in PsyAlliance.
CUSTOMIZE FIRST	Your state's rules on who may see your clients, your malpractice carrier's expectations, and what your informed consent already says about cover.

1. Before your time away

- [ ] Confirm your dates, including the day you return and the first day you are reachable again.
- [ ] List the clients who need cover and what each one needs: crisis contact only, or continued sessions.
- [ ] Check that each covering colleague is licensed in the client's state for the setting you have in mind (virtual or in person).
- [ ] Check your informed consent and any existing coverage agreement (PA-01) for what clients have already been told.
- [ ] Ask your malpractice carrier whether they need anything in writing about the arrangement.

2. Agree the arrangement with each colleague

- [ ] Agree what cover means for each client: urgent contact, crisis assessment, or routine sessions.
- [ ] Agree how urgent contacts reach the covering colleague and the expected response time.
- [ ] Agree what happens if the covering colleague is unavailable too (a second contact or local crisis services).
- [ ] Agree billing and records: who documents, where, and who bills for any session.
- [ ] Record the agreement in writing, even if only a short email.

3. Prepare a clean handover

- [ ] Share the minimum necessary information through your own secure, HIPAA-compliant channel, never through PsyAlliance messages.
- [ ] For each client: presenting concerns, current risk, safety plan, medication and prescriber, emergency contacts.
- [ ] Tell each client who is covering, how to reach them and for which dates.
- [ ] Set your voicemail and email auto-reply with the covering arrangements and crisis numbers (988 and 911).
- [ ] Confirm the handover is ready in your PsyAlliance plan.

4. When you return

- [ ] Get a short debrief from each covering colleague: contacts, sessions held, any risk events.
- [ ] Add the covering colleague's notes to the client record as your state and policies require.
- [ ] Thank your colleague, and offer to return the favour.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

Cover arrangements are shaped by state licensure, your informed consent and your malpractice policy. A covering colleague must be licensed in the state where the client is located at the time of contact. Share client information only through your own secure systems, on a minimum-necessary basis. This checklist is educational and is not legal or clinical advice.

NOTES